

**Berkeley Neighbors for Housing & Climate Action
2024 Candidate Questionnaire**

Candidate Name: Ben Bartlett

District / Office being sought: Berkeley City Council, District 3

1. Berkeley's Housing Element lays out the city's plan for new housing construction through 2031, ensuring the city can meet its Regional Housing Needs Allocation (RHNA) of ~9,000 homes across a range of income levels.

The Housing Element commits Berkeley to a number of major policy changes in order to meet state requirements for affirmatively furthering fair housing, including citywide zoning for "missing middle" housing, a San Pablo Specific Plan, an updated Demolition Ordinance, and upzoning along North Shattuck, Solano, and College Ave, among other items.

What is your view on the Housing Element and these policies? What are the most important things we need to do to implement the City's Housing Element?

Please discuss your ideas and priorities around:

- a. Missing Middle housing**
- b. San Pablo specific plan**
- c. Zoning for housing in high-resource neighborhoods like North Shattuck, Solano, and College Ave**

I've consistently been a leader in housing solutions in Berkeley, co-authoring the Missing Middle legislation that ended single-family zoning to promote more housing options and equity. Through this legislation, I am committed to creating affordable, accessible housing while dismantling historical barriers like redlining. Over 1,000 affordable homes have already been approved, and we've reduced homelessness by 45%, showing that we can meet bold housing goals through action.

In addition to these efforts, I spearheaded the Open Doors Initiative, which focuses on creating affordable homeownership opportunities for city workers and disadvantaged communities by converting single-family homes into multi-unit properties. This initiative is an essential part of our strategy to increase housing stock and offer more accessible pathways to homeownership, especially in historically exclusionary neighborhoods.

To fully implement the Housing Element, it's crucial we advance projects like the San Pablo Specific Plan to promote affordable, mixed-use housing that aligns with transit and commercial development. This area is primed for increased density, with its proximity to transit and commercial services. Proper zoning and planning here will contribute significantly to our city's housing goals.

Zoning for housing in high-resource neighborhoods like North Shattuck, Solano, and College Ave is equally essential. These areas have access to quality schools, public transit, and services that make them prime locations for new housing. Expanding

housing options in these neighborhoods ensures that all parts of our city contribute to addressing the housing crisis. It's about equity and creating opportunities for people of all income levels to live in Berkeley's most resource-rich areas.

Finally, I believe in maintaining a balanced approach that continues to protect vulnerable residents from displacement while incentivizing new housing development in missing middle and transit-oriented zones, ensuring we remain on track to meet the Housing Element's goals and create a Berkeley for all.

2. Berkeley's Climate Action Plan sets forth a goal of 80% reduction in greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions by 2050. Today, the two major sources of GHG emissions in Berkeley are from gas-powered automobiles and natural gas used in buildings.

Berkeley has a variety of plans and programs intended to help address these emissions, including the Electric Mobility Roadmap and the Berkeley Existing Building Electrification Strategy. Other related efforts include the Bicycle Plan and Pedestrian Master Plan, as well as the City's now-defunct natural gas ban on new buildings. Upcoming policy initiatives include the Berkeley Building Electrification and Just Transition Pilot Program, Measure GG, the Bay Area Air Quality Management District's regional ban on new NOx-emitting appliances, and more.

What is your view on the Climate Action Plan and these strategies? What are the most important things we need to do to address greenhouse gas emissions?

Please discuss your ideas and priorities around how Berkeley can reduce emissions from transportation and buildings, and how we should align the climate transition with our other goals as a city.

As a councilmember, I've been deeply committed to addressing climate change and ensuring Berkeley leads on climate action. I co-authored the Berkeley Green New Deal with Councilmember Terry Taplin, which set us on a path toward clean energy and sustainability. Our work has already secured historic investments in bike lanes, electric vehicle infrastructure, and green spaces. I'm proud of the progress we've made, including co-authoring the Electric Vehicle Charging Standard for new construction, which ensures that our city is prepared for the growing transition to EVs, but we must keep pushing forward.

The Climate Action Plan is a critical framework for reaching our goal of 80% greenhouse gas (GHG) reductions by 2050. To meet this goal, we need to continue implementing key strategies like the Berkeley Existing Building Electrification Strategy and the Electric Mobility Roadmap. Transitioning away from natural gas in buildings and reducing emissions from gas-powered vehicles are essential.

To reduce emissions from buildings, I fully support the Berkeley Building Electrification and Just Transition Pilot Program, which aims to electrify buildings while ensuring that the benefits of this transition are equitably shared, particularly with low-income communities. This program will help us phase out natural gas in buildings, which is a major source of emissions. I also support the Bay Area Air Quality Management District's regional ban on new NOx-emitting appliances, as this will further reduce emissions from buildings.

In terms of transportation, we must continue investing in electric vehicle infrastructure to support the growing number of EVs on the road. This includes expanding EV charging stations, especially in underserved areas, and encouraging the use of electric public transportation. I also support expanding protected bike lanes and improving pedestrian infrastructure to promote active transportation, reducing car dependency. As we advance these initiatives, it's essential that we align them with our goals of equity, ensuring that all communities, particularly low-income and historically marginalized groups, benefit from the transition to a green economy. This holistic approach will help Berkeley meet its climate goals while fostering a more inclusive and resilient city.

3. In your opinion, what was the most important City Council vote on Berkeley's housing crisis in the past four years? Briefly describe the issue, what you think of the Council's decision, and what you would have done had you been on the Council. For incumbents, please describe why you voted the way you did, and what you think now about that vote.

One of the most important City Council votes on Berkeley's housing crisis in the past four years was the vote to end single-family zoning through the Missing Middle legislation, which I co-authored with then Councilmembers Lori Droste and Rigel Robinson. This vote was crucial for addressing the housing shortage and advancing equity by undoing the legacy of redlining in Berkeley. By allowing for multi-unit housing in areas previously restricted to single-family homes, we opened the door to increased housing density and created more opportunities for affordable housing in every neighborhood, especially high-opportunity areas.

I supported this legislation because it was a necessary step in tackling Berkeley's housing crisis and ensuring that housing is more accessible for all. Looking back, I firmly believe this decision was the right one for our city, as it promotes inclusivity, increases housing stock, and supports our long-term goals of equitable housing development.

4. In your opinion, what was the most important climate or environmental issue faced by the Berkeley City Council in the last four years? Briefly describe the issue, what you think of the Council's decision, and what you would have done had you been on the Council. For incumbents, please describe why you voted the way you did, and what you think now about that vote.

The most important climate issue the Berkeley City Council faced in the last four years was the advancement of the Berkeley Green New Deal, which I co-authored with Councilmember Terry Taplin. This initiative set the framework for the city's transition toward clean energy, focusing on sustainable infrastructure, reducing greenhouse gas emissions, and implementing equitable green spaces.

One critical component was the effort to phase out natural gas use in buildings, a major source of emissions in Berkeley. The City Council passed policies aimed at electrifying existing buildings and supported the development of the Berkeley Building Electrification and Just Transition Pilot Program. Transitioning from fossil fuels is essential to meeting our climate goals. The decision aligned with our broader Climate Action Plan, which aims for an 80% reduction in greenhouse gas emissions by 2050.

These steps laid a solid foundation for the future of Berkeley's climate action leadership, positioning us to achieve significant emissions reductions while ensuring a just transition for low-income communities.

5. To achieve its RHNA goals, Berkeley must continue to build homes for all income levels. These new residents will need to travel within Berkeley. Greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions from transportation comprise roughly 60% of total emissions in Berkeley.

How would you ensure that Berkeley continues to reduce GHG emissions while adding new homes?

To ensure Berkeley continues to reduce GHG emissions while adding new homes, we must prioritize transit-oriented development, sustainable transportation options, and building electrification. As a Councilmember, I've co-authored the Berkeley Green New Deal and helped secure investments in bike lanes, electric vehicle infrastructure, and green spaces, which lay the groundwork for reducing transportation-related emissions.

Moving forward, we need to build more housing near transit corridors like BART and bus lines to reduce reliance on cars. I support expanding protected bike lanes, improving pedestrian infrastructure, and increasing access to electric vehicle charging stations, particularly in underserved areas.

In addition, we must align our housing growth with investments in public transportation, ensuring that new developments are accompanied by reliable, accessible, and low-emission transit options. This holistic approach will allow us to meet our housing goals while continuing to lower GHG emissions and move toward a more sustainable and equitable future for all residents.

6. Walking and biking presents opportunities to help Berkeley residents reduce their GHG emissions, but safety concerns can be a major deterrent. Of the two competing

street paving measures on the ballot this November, one of the major differences between the two is the approach to funding safety improvements for walking and biking.

Measure EE would provide safety funding only for traffic calming on bicycle boulevards and major pedestrian projects identified in the Pedestrian Plan. Measure FF would provide funding to implement safety measures throughout the city, based on existing plans.

What is your perspective on how we should address pedestrian and cyclist safety on our streets? What is your perspective on these two measures?

Pedestrian and cyclist safety is critical for reducing GHG emissions and ensuring a livable city. As a supporter of Measure FF, I believe that safety improvements should be implemented throughout the entire city, not just limited to certain areas like in Measure EE. Measure FF's approach allows for a more comprehensive investment in safety, addressing the needs of all neighborhoods and communities based on existing plans.

To truly support walking and biking as sustainable transportation options, we must ensure that our streets are safe for everyone, regardless of where they live or travel. This includes expanding protected bike lanes, improving pedestrian crossings, and implementing traffic-calming measures citywide. By making these investments, we can create safer, more walkable, and bike-friendly streets while also reducing our dependence on cars and lowering GHG emissions.

7. Berkeley has a long history of using zoning, restrictive covenants and redlining to achieve racial and economic segregation. This history continues to shape Berkeley today.

Recent research by the Turner Center at UC Berkeley suggests that inclusionary zoning requirements, which mandate on-site restricted affordable housing in new developments, may have the effect of reducing overall housing construction, including the production of affordable units. However, on-site affordable housing can also be an effective tool for desegregating neighborhoods.

What is your perspective on how Berkeley should use inclusionary zoning requirements, versus other affordable housing development options (such as in-lieu fees)?

Inclusionary zoning has been a valuable tool for creating affordable housing in Berkeley, but it must be balanced to avoid inadvertently slowing housing production. I believe we should continue using inclusionary zoning as a means to ensure that affordable housing is integrated into all neighborhoods, helping to desegregate historically segregated areas. However, we should also be flexible in our approach.

In cases where inclusionary zoning may make certain developments unfeasible, in-lieu fees can be an effective alternative, especially when directed towards larger affordable

housing projects that can provide more units at lower costs. By striking this balance, we can continue to build housing at all income levels, while still achieving our equity goals and increasing affordability across Berkeley.

The key is to maintain flexibility in our strategies—using inclusionary zoning where it supports neighborhood integration and leveraging in-lieu fees when they result in greater affordable housing production.

8. Many of the highest income neighborhoods in Berkeley are also in the Hillside Overlay, portions of which are in the California Very High Fire Hazard Severity Zone (CalFire VHFHSZ). How should we balance fire risk with affirmatively furthering fair housing?

We must ensure that even the highest-income neighborhoods, including those in the Hillside Overlay, contribute their fair share of affordable housing and increased density. While fire risk is a serious concern— I have been helping address it by campaigning for Measure FF in 2020, which provided critical fire prevention funding—it should not be used as an excuse to prevent housing development. Fire safety measures, such as vegetation management, building codes, and emergency response improvements, can and should be implemented. Still, they must be balanced with our goal of affirmatively furthering fair housing and ensuring that all neighborhoods, regardless of income, contribute to solving Berkeley's housing crisis.